Nicole Smith Oral History

Andrew Woods
00:19
Okay, we're at the First Division Museum at Cantini in Wheaton, Illinois, and it's uh Friday morning. I'm Andrew Woods. I'm the research historian at the First Division Museum and I'm speaking with Nicole Smith. And your rank was Sergeant. And in what unit?

Nicole Smith
00:41
121 Signal Battalion.

Andrew Woods
00:43
And we're also uh speaking with Kerry.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
00:47
Carrie Tarasuk.

Andrew Woods
00:48
Carrie Tarasuk.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
00:49
Assistant Curator of Collections. Yes.

Andrew Woods
00:52
Thank you very much. And uh Let's see. Um you were in the 121st Signal battalion, and that's uh division troops of the first division?

Nicole Smith
01:05
Yes, first

Andrew Woods
01:07
And um you served in other units prior to that?

Nicole Smith
01:10
Yes. I was in the 67 Cache before that, which is right down the road in Firstburgh. Let me think here.

01:19
I'll go backwards in chronological order. Okay. The 176th Signal Battalion, which is now disbanded at Fort Lewis.

01:27
122nd Signal Battalion in Korea, Camp Casey, which has now moved to Camp Red Cloud in Cape in Korea and also the sixteenth Sigma Battalion in Fort Hood.

Andrew Woods
01:39
And um what years were you in Korea then?

Nicole Smith
01:42
Oh yeah. 96 to 97. Yeah.

Andrew Woods
01:49
So so how long had you been in the army by the time you you joined the 121st uh Eight years. And uh d and you joined as a sergeant? Yes, yes. And uh so you served in uh Germany beforehand Um did you have any stories you wanted to tell us about uh your uh service in Germany with the First Division before going to Iraq?

Nicole Smith
02:17
Before going to Iraq?

Andrew Woods
02:19
Yeah.

Nicole Smith
02:21
Well I I got to um 121 Signal. We spent from mid-October until it was the 17th of December in the field getting ready for Iraq. That's my experience with prior to Iraq.

02:39
I mean we we went up for they said it was only supposed to be two weeks. Yeah. Then it turned into three weeks, then it turned into four weeks, and then it turned into almost two months.

02:47
Wow.

Andrew Woods
02:49
And of the things you did then what was most valuable to you later on?

Nicole Smith
02:54
Oh well just as a as a new soldier in the unit, the camaraderie of Just getting to know the soldiers and meet the soldiers and knowing who you're gonna deploy with.

Andrew Woods
03:10
And uh let's talk a bit about your your background. Um you were born

Nicole Smith
03:17
In Camp Hill, Pennsylvania.

Andrew Woods
03:19
And uh where did you enter service then?

Nicole Smith
03:22
Well the first time I came in in nineteen ninety four was Who w um the woman's. I came in. I was down there working at uh Avondale Shipyard and I was an exotic dancer on the side 'Cause uh it didn't pay uh working in the shipyard didn't pay that much.

Andrew Woods
03:39
Oh?

Nicole Smith
03:40
Minimum wage.

Andrew Woods
03:41
Really?

Nicole Smith
03:41
Okay. Minimum wage five twenty five what they started you out at.

Andrew Woods
03:44
Yeah. Um And what sort of things did you do in the shipyard?

Nicole Smith
03:50
Um actually it was the LSD 51, the Oak Hill that I worked on. I was actually there for the christening of it too. Pretty neat.

03:58
But um We'd strap down all the cables, the electronic, uh communication cables that ran from the ship, one end to the other, up down. Um, we ran them and then we'd have to go in and strap them down, which was connect them to the wall so they weren't hanging all over the place. and splice them together.

04:18
If somehow or other the cable got damaged while you were pulling it, then we'd have to cut it, splice it together, and then there was a shrink wrap stuff we had to stick over top of it and heat it so it would shrink. Not very glamorous.

Andrew Woods
04:33
But but uh the what kind of ship was that again? Uh was it a landing ship?

Nicole Smith
04:37
Um I was a precarious

Andrew Woods
04:39
A carrier. Yeah.

Nicole Smith
04:44
In fact, um at lunchtime one day when I was on day shift. the guys decided they were gonna go downstairs and play football in the inside this thing. Yeah, it was interesting.

Andrew Woods
04:55
So that was a huge ship to Oh it was huge

Nicole Smith
04:58
The pistons themselves that drive the were about two stories high.

Andrew Woods
05:03
So um well th that was that's almost like uh putting in telephones for a whole city then.

Nicole Smith
05:09
Oh yeah, oh yeah Was it um total cable? Everything that was on there is like 10,000 miles. Wow.

05:20
They gave us a book when they when they did the um when they christened it. They gave us

they put a magazine and it was covered to cover nothing but about the Oak Hill. So it was pretty interesting.

Andrew Woods
05:33
Um do you do you know what became of the ship subsequently where where the ship ended up?

Nicole Smith
05:40
Um it ended up up Where is that place? It's up north. Was it New Hampshire, Vermont? It's where they take 'em to mount all the the guns and stuff on it. And then don't know.

Andrew Woods
05:51
Okay. And what when was that? Uh what year was that?

Nicole Smith
05:57
1994.

Andrew Woods
05:59
Uh-huh. Um let's see, and uh we were talking earlier about why you joined the service. And did you want to tell us that story?

Nicole Smith
06:09
Uh I was actually an exotic dancer before I got the job with Avondale. I got the job with Avondale and I'm still dancing but I still had a hard time making bills and rent and stuff because it It takes a lot of money to buy costumes and it takes a lot of money to to be single and have a nice place. And I just got tired of it.

06:31
Medicine of not being able to make end meets and make ends meet and also the fact that a I ran into a friend of mine in New Orleans at a place called Big Daddy's And she was asking for help. She got tired of the dancing and stuff and she took me to a place where and she showed me what it was like where she how she ended up, how she lived and I didn't want to end up like that. And the sole purpose of this place was for the men, or correction, the women, to please the men, and that was it.

07:08
They had no rights, nothing. It was almost like I guess she could say white slavery is what he called it. So that's it, I wasn't gonna end up like that.

07:18
So it was time for a drastic change with no education, no money to go to college. What's the next best thing? The army.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
07:27
Had you ever thought of joining the military before that?

Nicole Smith
07:30
Yes. And I did in 1990. I went to basic training, but I had broken my collarbone the year before.

07:37
And I went to basic training, I was doing push-ups. And I went up and the drill sword says, down, soldier, and went to push me down and That was it, it snapped, it broke. So I got a medical discharge.

07:49
Had to wait two years to come back in. Hmm.

Andrew Woods
07:53
And uh had you had any family in the service before?

Nicole Smith
07:57
Yes my dad's a tradition. Dad was in Vietnam, 68, 69, um Marines, the third division, Company H Nicknamed uh Bastroach Best. I know I like the nickname too. It's kind of funny.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
08:14
Did that persuade you in any way to join? How did that influence you

Nicole Smith
08:20
Well, I don't know, just growing up. My family is very patriotic and support the military, support our country of freedom. And even if they don't support the war that we fight in, they still support us and the soldiers because, you know, we make the decision to volunteer and we make this the decision to Want to help others to get where we're at at whatever cost, whatever it takes. Okay.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
08:52
So it's sort of an ideology that you adopted. Yeah. Okay.

Andrew Woods

08:57
And is there any reason that you decided on the branch of service of the Army in particular?

Nicole Smith
09:05
I don't know what made me decide on the Army.

Andrew Woods
09:08
Um rather than like the Navy or

Nicole Smith
09:10
Well the Marines, forget it. Their basic training was too tough for me. Um well with my broken collarbone, the Marines wouldn't take me either.

09:18
Um the Navy, I don't like water. I don't like water at all. The Air Force Um you still had to spend some time in the water with the Air Force.

09:29
And I didn't I don't like water in the army. No water involved.

Andrew Woods
09:34
How is it you ended up in New Orleans?

Nicole Smith
09:38
Um my brother was living down there. And I went down to stay with him. Just a change of scenery and Who doesn't want to see New Orleans?

09:48
Oh yeah. You got a chance to go. Yeah.

09:51
Jump at it. It's wonderful down there.

Andrew Woods
09:55
And I I know I like it down there. Okay. And what specialties did you train in when you joined?

Nicole Smith
10:01
Communications.

Andrew Woods

10:03
And What what uh part of communications?

Nicole Smith
10:07
Um it's a 31 Fox, which is now called a 25 Fox, which is the technic technical name for it is network switching systems operator It's switchboards, the modern switchboards with the computers and phones and still running cables.

Andrew Woods
10:23
So it's both telephone and computer.

Nicole Smith
10:26
Right, right. And also radios too, the sing on

Andrew Woods
10:30
And let's see, where were you stationed after you joined the army then? Well, we went over that already. I'm sorry. Um let's see, what when did you leave uh Germany then with the First Division? And how did you get over get away from uh Germany over to uh the Middle East

Nicole Smith
10:56
Oh, we flew. They bust us down to what was that? Rammstein. They bust us down to Ramstein, loaded us on the It was a civilian plane crammed us in there.

Andrew Woods
11:11
Yeah. How mu how much of the unit were they able to fit? Uh

Nicole Smith
11:18
Uh well the plane could fit like 500 plus people. Yeah. I mean it it was huge. It was either 300 plus or 500 plus. I know it took a couple flights But I know um they got pretty much everybody on from our battalion.

Andrew Woods
11:34
Yeah.

Nicole Smith
11:35
Pretty much everybody.

Andrew Woods
11:36
Yeah And uh what was the seating like on on a flight like that?

Nicole Smith
11:41
Oh wow. You had We were so tight, I mean your legs would fall asleep because you had to ha you we had our rucksacks, those sat on our laps, we had our weapons, those you know, on the floor or right there beside you for those that were paranoid and didn't want to lose 'em or didn't want to get 'em mixed up with somebody else's. It was tight. Plus we had on all of our LBV flag vest Kavlar.

Andrew Woods
12:08
Was it was it separate seats or benches or oh it was it was separate seats but it might as well have been a bench.

Nicole Smith
12:14
Yeah. Because I mean if you had one seat if the people were small enough you'd get three people sitting in between that. It was if it was a a seat for five soldiers, you might have six in there if you could fit another one in.

Andrew Woods
12:28
So so they did a everything they could to shoehorn the whole b as much of the battalion anyway.

Nicole Smith
12:35
We were sardine.

Andrew Woods
12:36
One flight.

Nicole Smith
12:36
Yeah, we were seriously sardined.

Andrew Woods
12:38
And how how long did it take you to Fly down.

Nicole Smith
12:42

Oh well. I c I couldn't remember how long. It was it was so hot and stuffy in there half a must pass.

Andrew Woods
12:48
Was it was it one straight trip or or did they make any stops

Nicole Smith
12:53
Nope one straight trip. Um they flew us down to Kuwait from Kuwait they bust us they bust us from the airport up to um what was that camp we were at? I can't remember the name of the camp.

Andrew Woods
13:11
Um, but the this map wouldn't help, I don't think it.

Nicole Smith
13:14
No, that's the IRI camp.

Andrew Woods
13:16
Well, go on anyway, son. Um so you went to a camp in Kuwait.

Nicole Smith
13:21
Right.

Andrew Woods
13:22
And then how long were you there and what was going on when you arrived there?

Nicole Smith
13:26
We spent a month there. It took about two weeks for all of our trucks and equipment, trailers, generators to show up. We bust down back down to the port, which was really awesome.

13:37
I mean when you pull up to this port there is nothing but military equipment and they have trucks stacked. They had like level almost like a parking garage, but they were single. They had 'em stacked on each other and they'd drive 'em off and then park 'em for us to get there.

13:56
It was just absolutely amazing. This it was filled, filled. I'd say it was probably about ten fifteen acre lot is nothing but military equipment.

14:08
Everything from the tanks, the Bradleys you name it. It was just awesome. But anyhow, we we would con then we convoy back up to our um base in Kuwait And then we'd start training.

14:23
Yeah.

Andrew Woods
14:23
And uh what kind of vehicles were you in the af after the bus and all of that? What Uh Humvees.

Nicole Smith
14:34
Hum Humvees.

Andrew Woods
14:35
Yes.

Nicole Smith
14:35
The 1097, 1037, 998s

Andrew Woods
14:42
Um are those the up-armored?

Nicole Smith
14:44
No, they weren't up armored at the time.

Andrew Woods
14:47
And uh were were they armed at all?

Nicole Smith
14:49
Did did you have At the time no No, not for Kuwait. But once we were get that's part of what we did once we got to Kuwait, we put up armor on those that they could get up armor for um a cr correction. The commander and first sergeant Yeah, do you know just the commander's vehicle was up armored. That's it.

Andrew Woods
15:08
Yeah.

Nicole Smith

15:08
Because I was had on armor. Yeah. I was a first arms driver and we had uh Kavillar seat covers.

Andrew Woods
15:16
Yeah.

Nicole Smith
15:17
And we had to put sandbags. We put sandbags in between the the big space between the driver and the passenger, in the back, on the floorboards, under the seats. Some of the seats we had to take out.

15:29
'Cause they wouldn't fit like the batteries. You put sandbags over top and you couldn't get the seat cover back on. So you just either lay the Kavlar over top of it or you just sit on sandbags.

Andrew Woods
15:39
Yeah Uh you didn't have to do that as driver though, did you?

Nicole Smith
15:43
No, no. They they tried to be a little bit more comfortable with the driver. Yeah. The passenger seat has the battery on the driver's side, you just put it underneath.

15:52
Yeah. But and then when you get in to shut the door you had a sandbag that was tucked in 'Cause it was just soft doors. He'd tuck it into the side and shut the door and if the door didn't shut then you tied it shut.

Andrew Woods
16:06
Well what do you mean soft doors?

Nicole Smith
16:08
Um just plastic. Canvas. Just plastic. Yeah. It was kinda scary driving convoying through Iraq, you know Soft doors.

Andrew Woods
16:20
Um was it uh was there any advantage to that being more airy or anything? So there's no reason for them not to have a steel door, huh?

Nicole Smith

16:30
Nope. No, even the dust. I mean it was dusty. Half the time you couldn't especially at night time you couldn't see the um vehicle in front of you. And we had our lights on and everything just so we could see in front of us.

Andrew Woods
16:43
Did you have communications between uh vehicles?

Nicole Smith
16:46
Not between every single vehicle. The front vehicle, the lead vehicle had one, the trail vehicle had one. and there was a vehicle in the middle, which would have been the commander. He shifted places in the middle and our um tow truck would have comms and that's it

Andrew Woods
17:04
Did you always stay with a vehicle that had communication or did you ever get split with the Well as far as a convoy goes, you always had communications in a convoy.

Nicole Smith
17:14
Yeah But wherever you sat is wherever you sat in whatever vehicle. Mm-hmm. But if you change places if you change places with somebody in a different vehicle, you had to notify the convoy commander. 'Cause if anything happened to that vehicle, they needed to know who was inside that vehicle. And the only way to know is the convoy commander has that information.

Andrew Woods
17:33
Wow.

Nicole Smith
17:34
Yeah.

Andrew Woods
17:36
And so uh you eventually went from Uh well what did you do in Kuwait before you went on into Iraq then? Any anything else you wanted to talk about

Nicole Smith
17:49
That's about it.

Andrew Woods
17:50

We just trained and went to the simulator and and so uh that when did you go up into Iraq? What was and what was the situation when when you went up there? uh what was going on as far as the the war at that time.

Nicole Smith
18:09
Well without communications we really didn't know what was going on. I mean we had communications between each other but there was no news, there was no T V. I mean we just you only knew what they would tell us. And they would tell us that um we had these maps that we would use. Just in case we got separated, here's the map, here's the route we're taking. And uh we knew by the hot zone as to the color on the map that that was supposed to be a hot zone

Andrew Woods
18:38
Yeah.

Nicole Smith
18:38
And I think it was yellow. It was yellow with little hash marks to it. And that was like, okay, we're in for some trouble, put the and night vision goggles on and You know, we we rolled locked and loaded. We were all unsafe, but we were locked and we had a a a round in the chamber. So We were constantly ready.

Andrew Woods
18:59
What about uh helmets or uh body armor and always on.

Nicole Smith
19:03
Always on. Sixty-five pounds.

Andrew Woods
19:06
Wellproof best.

Nicole Smith
19:07
Yeah, supposed to be. Yeah.

Andrew Woods
19:11
But uh it m did you ever have that tested?

Nicole Smith
19:16

No, thank heavens. No.

Andrew Woods
19:20
And uh so so uh you drove up to replace another uh division in Iraq?

Nicole Smith
19:27
Mm-hmm.

Andrew Woods
19:28
And which unit did you replace there?

Nicole Smith
19:31
Was it the fourth? The clover leaf? Yes, the clover leaf out of uh Ford Hood.

Andrew Woods
19:37
Yeah That would be the Fourth Infantry Division.

Nicole Smith
19:41
Okay. Yeah.

Andrew Woods
19:42
And that was up in what city?

Nicole Smith
19:45
We rolled up into to crit.

Andrew Woods
19:47
Yes.

Nicole Smith
19:48
Mm-hmm.

Andrew Woods
19:49
And where's that in relationship to Baghdad?

Nicole Smith
19:53

North. Yes. North, yes.

19:55
Well all the um because of our signal, each company had teams that supported different infantry units, different infantry companies throughout. So they would actually convoy with like if we had a team that was supposed to go south east. someplace everybody convoyed to Tukrit and then from there they split off and they convoyed out with the units that they were there to support.

Andrew Woods
20:27
Yes.

Nicole Smith
20:27
So we actually had we weren't all located Our headquarters was located in Tukrent on Fob Danger. Right. But we had people all over Iraq. All over It was just amazing where I went.

Andrew Woods
20:41
And you in particular, were you with headquarters or were you assigned to uh another unit?

Nicole Smith
20:47
I was assigned to headquarters. I worked as the uh M one of the soldiers for the MWR on danger.

Andrew Woods
20:54
Which is MWR?

Nicole Smith
20:56
Um morale, welfare and recreation.

Andrew Woods
20:58
Yes. And um did you notice any difference when you were uh convoying up from Kuwait? Um was was there uh any any difference in different parts of the country as you were getting to Oh yeah.

Nicole Smith
21:14
When we fur well it was nighttime when we first crossed the border, so you really couldn't tell. But um Going through Kuwait, it was clean. You really didn't see a lot of people walking on the

roads and it just it was healthy and it was We crossed over in the the town right there on the border as you cross into Iraq.

21:36
When we crossed over through, kids just came out. You know, they wanted things. They were looking for food or handouts Once it got daylight and we started seeing the difference, you could tell where our armies went through the the the desolation the I don't really know how to ex to describe it.

22:02
And it wasn't it wasn't beautiful at all But the closer you got to Baghdad you realized that where you just came through was actually beautiful compared to Baghdad. And there were places in Baghdad where it was completely level. Yeah.

22:15
And there was people living in the you know the collapsed roofs of their homes that are diagonal they're camped out underneath it, lost everything

Andrew Woods
22:27
So so for uh say s south of Baghdad then going through there there was some combat damage, but once you

Nicole Smith
22:41
Once you got to Baghdad is when you really got to see a change. Where you really got to see The destruction and stuff.

Andrew Woods
22:47
Had any c reconstruction taken place yet or was it still combat situation there?

Nicole Smith
22:54
I'd say it was still a combat situation. Because you saw our troops out there patrolling the streets and it was There was a lot going on. I mean, it's like everywhere you looked, we got lost in Baghdad. We took the wrong turn, the whole convoy. And one particular place where they decided to turn around, the people wouldn't let us turn around. Traffic was so bad and they just pushed pushing people out of the way, their cars, so we could get through

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
23:22
Seeing all that, how did that how did that affect you and the soldiers who were with you, seeing all that destruction?

Nicole Smith
23:30
Uh you kind of It's sad to see it, but at the same time it's almost liberating to know that finally the United States decided to do something about um Saddam and the way that he treats his people and it might have been a little extreme, but you do what you gotta do. And some of them wanted us there. It was cool if the ones that wanted us there, we'd go by and they'd be screaming and

Andrew Woods
24:00
Just wave in and you were saying at the very border there were there were kids. What what about when you got further in country like when you're in the city of Bad Baghdad going through there? Um anybody that would try to get close?

Nicole Smith
24:13
Yeah. We'd Hold our rifles on him. Yeah. No. We actually had our safety off and our finger off the trigger but holding it

Andrew Woods
24:22
So so th there's there's uh still enemy in the area, so you have to be You don't know who's the enemy and who's not.

Nicole Smith
24:30
And this is our first time rolling in and we don't know And y you look at some you look at you can't tell, you don't know.

Andrew Woods
24:39
Um was there any uh how how was it different in Tikrit when you were there from uh Baghdad

Nicole Smith
24:47
Well, we rolled up into Tukrit and I never left base. I was one of the soldiers that they left on base all the time. Yeah.

24:55
And I had uh I tore the ligament in my knee. So that pretty much put me um carrying a lot of weight. When we first left we had to carry Minus the what they called the sappy plates, the um our everything.

25:15
We had um two duffel bags, a rucksack, our weap um our weapon, the ammunition that we had

to carry. It's 200 rounds. We had all that stuff that we had to carry.

25:27
And if you just so happened to like we'd help other soldiers carry too. We had a female, she was what, five one And we were all helping her taking turns, helping her carry her stuff.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
25:39
Now this is the you said sixty-five pounds that was that's with the sappy plates

Nicole Smith
25:44
Okay. It was either sixty five or sixty eight.

Andrew Woods
25:46
And the Safi plates are extra body armor?

Nicole Smith
25:49
Yes, that's actually the body armor.

Andrew Woods
25:51
Okay.

Nicole Smith
25:52
You Velcro, you know, you tear your stuff apart, shove it in and slap it back together. We had the I know for us when we got issued all we had was the breastplate, the back plate, and that was it. Um the rest of the w that's all we got issued. But they were they were heavy.

Andrew Woods
26:12
Um did you see With the other branches of the service, like if if you were in infantry, did they have different body armor than you did?

Nicole Smith
26:22
Oh yeah. Oh yeah. Um excuse me.

26:26
Um We had um net guards too. They they just velcroed on in the front and uh that we had the groin plates, but for those of us that were short the little groin plate hung down past our knees. So we need rocky trip.

26:44
So most of us just stuffed them up inside. But um for the infantry that in front it was a tanker Yeah. And he had a plate that actually went in the back of his the back of his head and for his neck.

26:57
And it it added weight, but you know, they needed it more than we did And oh what they oh the the shoulder they had the shoulder guards as well too that went part way down.

Andrew Woods
27:10
Are you talking a tanker truck or a tank tanked tankers the soldiers?

Nicole Smith
27:15
Um in fact they were with um quarter calf, Charlie Bat was it Charlie Battery? Yeah, Charlie Battery. But they they had all the extra gear.

27:25
I mean they were issued elbow pads, knee pads. just because they spent a lot of time on the ground. When they weren't in their tanks patrolling or firing them things off, they were out actually doing foot patrols.

Andrew Woods
27:39
So it's a little bit of a And were you in your vehicle most of the time, but you had enough time on foot that that was I didn't go on foot outs outside the gate at all.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
27:50
At all Yeah, I'm curious. I just wanna re just wanna return momentarily. You said that, you know, um you would pull you guys would pull your guns on the Iraqis if they if they came close or something. I'm just I I feel like this is maybe somewhat an obvious question, but How did they how did they respond to that?

Nicole Smith
28:08
Most of them turn around and just walk away and they just that was okay. The whole time we convoyed we had our weapons out our window. Mm-hmm. The whole time we convoyed. Mm-hmm. But if they looked like they were getting too close, then we'd

Andrew Woods
28:22
Did you see any of them obviously carrying weapons?

Nicole Smith
28:26
No. most of the time it was I mean you're just scanning your area trying to you're trying to take in as much as you can but at the same time be aware of what's going on inside the vehicle. Yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
28:39
The people that that did come around, were they I mean, any particular age group or did you notice anything? Doesn't matter, just all people of all types.

Nicole Smith
28:49
Men, women, okay. It's all types.

Andrew Woods
28:54
And and is that the same in decrete as in uh debt?

Nicole Smith
28:58
Yeah.

Andrew Woods
28:59
Um was was it as tense in TikT uh as it was in in Baghdad?

Nicole Smith
29:05
No, it wasn't as bad. No. It wasn't as bad. I think a lot of the people in Tikrit actually liked us.

Andrew Woods
29:13
So so probably that that crowd situation in Baghdad where they wouldn't let you turn around, was that one of the the tensest situations um for the travel up or were there other reasons.

Nicole Smith
29:28
Oh actually the whole the whole trip was tense. The the whole trip was. Because I was lucky enough to be in a vehicle where we had communication.

Andrew Woods
29:37
Yeah.

Nicole Smith
29:38

And we actually caught up to the convoy in front of us and we'd have to stop and we'd have to stop for fuel and every time we stopped for fuel Um if we weren't within the safe perimeter, we still had to get out and pool guard. So the whole trip was tense. So you couldn't sleep the whole time either. You you had to be awake. there it you had to be awake.

Andrew Woods
30:03
And uh just to clarify for me, this this was after uh the US troops had taken Baghdad and Tikrete and and defeated the Iraqi regular army.

Nicole Smith
30:17
This was um February 2004 to because we arrived in TikTok on the first of March 2004

Andrew Woods
30:27
So the so uh the US Army had been in for uh almost uh a year.

Nicole Smith
30:34
Almost a year.

Andrew Woods
30:38
And uh in uh to create um you're in charge of communications there. Um did you have to rebuild that whole system

Nicole Smith
30:51
No, it was already in place.

Andrew Woods
30:53
Okay.

Nicole Smith
30:53
The um the unit um the unit that we took over for was 16th Signal out of Fort Hood, Texas.

Andrew Woods
31:00
Yes.

Nicole Smith
31:01
We their equipment, most of their equipment stayed in place. Because they had the system up,

they had the network working, and why take down something that's already working? And some of our equipment we didn't have some of the stuff that was needed for this system.

31:21
But some of the vehicles we did actually swap out and they took some of their stuff home Yeah. And when we left some of our stuff stayed in place because the people that replaced us, the soldiers, sorry, um, was National Guard Reserve and their equipment hadn't been updated like ours was. Yeah.

31:39
So a lot of our stuff plus with um Bravo one two one being disbanded It wasn't gonna hurt just to leave the equipment there.

Andrew Woods
31:48
I see. Um and was there anybody in the 16th that you had known from when you served them before?

Nicole Smith
31:56
No

Andrew Woods
31:57
No. It it all changed over since then.

Nicole Smith
31:59
Yeah, it all changed over. But I didn't I did meet a a few people down there I was in the army with before different um A Sergeant First Class um Harvey, first name Donnell. He was actually with um 29th SIG out of Fort Lewis.

32:19
He was the first sergeant for Bravo Company. I ran into him while I was down there. That was pretty interesting.

Andrew Woods
32:25
Now now Bravo Company, B Company, was that uh your company in the 121st or was that no I was headquarters. Okay.

Nicole Smith
32:34
HAC oh HAC.

Andrew Woods

32:37
Headquarters Headquarters Company I should have remembered.

Nicole Smith
32:40
Headquarters yeah

Andrew Woods
32:43
And let's see here. Um what was the first combat experience that you had in Iraq then?

Nicole Smith
32:53
being shelled for um one day in particular. Twenty-eight um mortars were fired in. Nobody got hit, nobody got hurt Every Americans got hurt or hit or it was um I was walking up to the MWR.

33:13
the palace that we lived in the palaces. They had them we lived in on cots and but uh we lived down by the lake area. And to get to the MWR you had to walk up this kind of steep hill and walk in front of on the in the news when they first went into um Saddam's little secret area where he's got like those twenty-seven, twenty-eight palaces.

Andrew Woods
33:38
Yeah.

Nicole Smith
33:39
The one that they blew up on TV. Yeah. And they showed it on the news.

33:43
Um you had to walk in front of that place. I was just walking. I was going up the hill and they've been hitting all day and usually they just hit the embankment or they hit that palace.

33:53
Most of the time that's where they hit I was like but that day, I mean, they were hitting there. They they were just randomly hitting all over the pa all over base.

Andrew Woods
34:02
Yeah.

Nicole Smith
34:03
I don't think they could aim very well I don't really think they had a s air.

Andrew Woods
34:07
Was was the palace like the tallest structure?

Nicole Smith
34:12
Yeah, it was the the highest one.

Andrew Woods
34:13
Maybe they were far away and just aiming at the tallest thing they could see.

Nicole Smith
34:19
Well, they knew that our communications was right equipment was right behind there. That's where all of our the the hub headquarters was.

Andrew Woods
34:26
Yeah.

Nicole Smith
34:28
And all the palaces there belonged to Saddam, correct? Yes. Okay.

34:32
Yes. At one time he uh no, not all of 'em. Not all not every single one.

34:37
Most of 'em did. Some of 'em were um Depending on how close they were to Saddam is the is to which palaces that they lived in.

Andrew Woods
34:47
Family relation or political relationship?

Nicole Smith
34:49
Family relation. Or political, yeah. The the closer and the more that he trusted them, the closer that they lived and the bigger the palaces that they lived in. You know, and So on and so on.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
35:00
So is the one that you you guys stayed in? Was it one of Saddams?

Nicole Smith
35:04

Um they say that that particular one belonged to one of his sons. Okay And this one was unusual. On the outside, it was kind of like a clover leaf shape, the the three clover leaf.

35:17
On the outside, around the edge there was the history of the Iraq-Iran war when Saddam took over. And on one place around on the back side of it, he did there's a picture that depicts the an Iraqi holding um it has three so American soldiers because they have US on their shoulder holding um one's on his knees and they have a a weapon pointed at his head and there's two others tied up behind and the guards are hold standing there holding weapons to garden them. And it's showing the him overtaking the Americans the first time that we went in.

36:01
Wow. Which we know is a lie. We just we let him go and pulled out.

Andrew Woods
36:07
Um do you think they had any uh prisoners uh there I know I know uh only of one that was declared dead during the war and that they said was was missing. But did did you ever

Nicole Smith
36:25
Any prisoners?

Andrew Woods
36:27
Hear about any any prisoners being being taken there or anything like that?

Nicole Smith
36:33
I never heard of any well we had not before we got there, but when we got there, we actually had a prison on there. Yeah. That we that they put the Iraqis and stuff in. Okay one time um at the palace where I worked at the case. No, what did I know of?

Andrew Woods
36:54
But I'm sorry you were telling me about it.

Nicole Smith
36:57
Uh we had um they brought this old guy in. We had to shut down the MWR Palace and we had to pull guard Um, Ambassador Bremer came down and they questioned this guy. He was so old his back popped every time he took a step.

37:11
And he he walked hunched over He was some kind of political prisoner. One of the ones on the

card. We had the cards.

37:19
We didn't know who he was. We couldn't really see his face or anything. And they stuck him in a little room and we had to guard it till the MPs got there and until Ambassador Brehmer and General Batiste got down there.

37:30
Yeah. I think that was like kind of exciting. Just because it was just it just was.

Andrew Woods
37:38
Yeah, I I noticed you had an ambassador Bremer uh story on on the back here Um oh that was the farewell dinner, so so that's later on I'm assuming.

Nicole Smith
37:50
He was he was a very nice man, Amaster Barbara. He used to come up to the NWR to get his hair cut, he'd come up and do some shopping and He he was busy, very busy. He used to have luncheons up at the MWR all the time.

38:04
But um that I remember the the farewell one only because uh he sent the letter Um it was like a generic letter to our NCO that oversaw the NWR as a thank you to all the soldiers for his dinner going, his farewell going so well. So and he the and the really cool part is that he didn't know about um He knew about the farewell dinner, but he didn't know everything that was going to take place at it. So it was kind of neat.

Andrew Woods
38:37
Um and you had uh on your survey you mentioned the the uh Best story that you'd like to tell is about a Fourth of July celebration?

Nicole Smith
38:48
Yeah. Picture this. it picture about a hundred, two hundred Iraqi dignitaries and American dignitaries eating all kinds of food, drinking, laughing, smoking inside a building, which was unusual.

39:06
We go outside for the celebration. This is the first class of the Iraqi National Guard to graduate. Fireworks, fireworks are going, everybody's enjoying it.

39:19
The little kids they brought on um some of the Iraqi kids, as soon as the fireworks started, the

first boom they ran for cover. It was it was funny but it but it wasn't funny if that makes sense. They were scared.

39:32
And then they got to see the and their eyes just lit up as soon as they're like, Oh, fireworks? They'd never seen 'em before. Well They caught the bank on fire.

39:44
The whole bank. Oh my gosh. Just uh you saw this little fire.

39:48
I have it on videotape You you saw this like the sparks just fine like oh it'll go out, you know, it's you know it's dry and all of a sudden it just starts going, starts going. And it started at the base of the hill and went all the way up and you could see the flame shooting over the hill. That was but what it they couldn't put it out.

40:08
We didn't have fire trucks, we didn't have hoses. So they're with like fire extinguishers just making sure it doesn't come close to the other fireworks that they haven't set off yet. It was it was it was actually funny.

40:23
I mean it really was. Everybody thought it was part of the show. We all thought it was part of the show.

40:29
And then it was just like all of a sudden it gets out of control and we're like, um, no, it's not part of the show And the Iraqis that just graduated from the class are sitting down there on the road and they're not moving. And it's like it it's like they all realized at the same time that this fire is starting to get out of control. Yeah.

40:47
And it was like they're just starting moving. Yeah. But they they put it out.

40:51
They got the bulldozers and they just pushed sand over top of it and p out it went.

Andrew Woods
40:56
What did you think of the Iraqi soldiers

Nicole Smith
41:00
We really didn't have a lot of interaction with them. They would bring them to the MWR um once in a while. They'd bring up small groups.

41:10
They brought up a big group one time, a whole class It was actually scary because they came into our sports bar area where the pool tables and stuff were and they would sit there and they would just stare at us and just stare and it's like um we were the females we were uncomfortable. We were very uncomfortable. So we ended up going and getting some of the male soldiers and even though they were guarded and even though they were supposed to be not a threat to us.

41:42
We weren't comfortable anyhow.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
41:44
I don't blame you.

Nicole Smith
41:45
So we went and they said we went and we got some of the male soldiers and we left. We left them there to deal with them That that was the only time that they brought him up in such large numbers.

Andrew Woods
41:56
What yeah, what kind of things would uh you do at the recreation center and uh what what sort of activities did you have?

Nicole Smith
42:03
Well they had they had pool tables, dartboards, um they had huge TVs. We had movies, they the soldiers they'd come up and pick whatever they wanted to watch. Um We have board games, card games, they'd have competitions, dominoes, and um well they had a gym, 24 hours. Um there was a computer room. Soldiers can check their email and video conference.

Andrew Woods
42:29
Yeah.

Nicole Smith
42:30
And there was a bazaar. The chaplain's office was in there too. Yeah. And the the church So where they also had the um ceremonies for those that are.

Andrew Woods
42:41
So did you enable the the email back home for the soldiers? Was that part of what you did

there?

Nicole Smith
42:47
No, we didn't do it. Um we just we kept the system up and running and if there was any problems we had to go in and fit you know flip the switch and We had a phone tent outside, the ATT, and because of my civilian communication experience and they couldn't always get an ATT person up there they gave me the code to get in to flip the switch or do some of the programming once in a while. Because I knew I basically knew what I had to do to fix it to get it back up But yeah that was Sar Smith the phones are down come fix them man I just went to bed can't wait till morning no They gave me a little um I had a little Toyota truck that I drove.

43:34
So 'cause I used to pick up all the supplies for the sports bar. We sold um to make money to pay for prizes for the competitions that they would have. We um we were given six hundred dollars to start I go to the um PX, talk to the AFES personnel, and they'd give us a they'd give us a break on the stuff that we bought.

43:57
And then any money that we would make, like I said, it would go to to purchase prizes for the soldiers so they could have some neat prizes instead of anything that would be not so nice. Yeah.

Andrew Woods
44:09
Not just something laying around.

Nicole Smith
44:11
Yeah, exactly. Exactly. Because we had a bazaar there. And they sold everything from cigarettes um silk scarves, um paintings.

Andrew Woods
44:23
Uh Iraqi merchants?

Nicole Smith
44:25
Yes, yes. Um the fake Rolexes and the fake s fake Cordier excuse me, Courtier Watt How do you say that qu qu'y that's it? Cutter watches.

44:37
Yeah, half the time they didn't work or I bought a fake uh Rolex, Folex we called them. You'd have to shake it 'cause it was a wind up or I'm sorry, it worked off your your skin. You'd have to

shake it, it would stop and you'd have to shake it really hard again.

44:51
Definitely not reliable for time. But yeah, they sold all kinds of stuff up there. I mean just all kinds of stuff.

Andrew Woods
44:59
Um, oh did you ever see any uh like antiquities uh Oh yeah.

Nicole Smith
45:04
Oh yeah. They had this huge sword. Huge.

45:08
The guy said it was like a hundred years old, but we can't we couldn't buy stuff like that. One it was a weapon, two it was an antique. So we couldn't we we would have not been able to get it out of the country.

Andrew Woods
45:20
Or I remember seeing like monument swords. Um that that's not what you're talking about though, is it?

Nicole Smith
45:27
No, this was an a sword that um way back when their the guards would use it was actually the fighting swords that they would carry. Um was the best way to describe it to It would be the equivalent of uh our nights. Uh-huh.

45:47
And the round table and all that stuff. Yeah. Rugs.

45:52
They would have antique rugs too. They would bring in. They're just old.

45:56
They weren't they're not worth much though. Yeah, not worth much at all. 'Cause I bought one.

46:02
I bought three Took them back home and took them to a rug dealer and was told that they were not very high quality.

Andrew Woods
46:11
Yeah.

Nicole Smith
46:12
But that's okay. I watched the lady make it.

Andrew Woods
46:14
Well that's the place to get one.

Nicole Smith
46:16
Oh yeah. Well the the one I bought I watched the lady make it. Yeah. And she wouldn't let me take a picture, so her son uh took a picture of him, myself, and the rug. That's uh just to record that that's where I got it at and that's who I got it from and the date and everything.

Andrew Woods
46:33
Oh and I wanted to make sure that you could mention some of the soldiers you served with, uh who was your commanding officer, who did you work with the most?

Nicole Smith
46:42
Uh who did I work with most? I worked with a whole bunch of other soldiers. At the MWR it was a collection of the units had to provide one to two soldiers.

46:53
to help support the MWR for all the other soldiers. Um Anderson, first name Bobby. Bobby J, that's what most of the people would call him.

47:08
But uh he was the master in charge of the MWR. Command Sergeant Major Chase from 4-3. He was the biggest supporter of the MWR facility.

47:17
And uh my first sergeant, first Sergeant Comarty. P. S. Ivania, Jessica, from Texas. She's a twin.

47:28
In fact, this uh quilt that I made in Iraq. She has the other quilt pieces, the leftover pieces. I made her a summer quilt for her 21st birthday.

47:39
Um Staff Sergeant Robinson. Actually he's a Sarn First Class now. He's with the first ID band.

47:48
He was a big supporter of the soldiers. Very big supporter. Very smart.

47:53

Very, very smart man too. He used to, they started a uh poetry and a book reading, a book group. So he was part of that.

Andrew Woods
48:05
Did that have Iraqi involv involvement as well, or was that all American?

Nicole Smith
48:10
It was also American. Well yeah. A lot of us The Iraqis that worked at the MWR, we had 12 that worked to help clean the building.

48:22
And there was about 12 to 14 that worked in the bazaar area. We became friends with a few of them. But it was in November.

48:35
They had a uh November 2004. They had a rash of they started getting killed, knocked off. And we don't We had fired a tailor, the original tailor that we had.

48:53
He was stealing from the government. He was changing his paperwork so he'd get more money. And um he got caught and he got fired.

49:04
Well that was like three yeah, three weeks later. Then all of a sudden people that worked upstairs in the bazaar started getting knocked off They were just so we ended up closing the bazaar down. We quit.

Andrew Woods
49:20
Everybody came in, packed up their stuff and Was that about the same time in November as the Fallujah battle?

Nicole Smith
49:28
Yeah Help.

Andrew Woods
49:30
So was was this after that battle that that things got worse?

Nicole Smith
49:36
Yeah, it was a little bit after that, yeah. Yeah, come to think of it. Yeah, 'cause uh one of the places I used to go visit the um I used to hang out with the de facto personnel. There were

civilians. Most of them were from Britain and all that And uh yeah, that was, because one night um Major Payne, who's the general's aide, came down and I helped them get together a uh couple flats of coffee and sugar and dry creamer to send down to the soldiers in Fallujah.

Andrew Woods
50:12
And uh I I believe that was the second of the second.

Nicole Smith
50:18
Um I I don't I don't remember. I just know he said the general sent down a message and said look our our boys need some coffee. Let's send them some coffee because they were asking for it.

50:31
Then he's like send him some coffee. And it was to everybody. The the Marines, it didn't matter who they were.

50:36
He shared it with everyone.

Andrew Woods
50:38
What was the coffee like there?

Nicole Smith
50:41
Coffee. Unfortunately it was American coffee, yes. Yes.

50:49
Now if you got to know the Iraqis, they brought you in coffee And want to talk about some strong coffee. You take a handful of it, boil some water in a pot, just throw it in there, let it boil for a little bit Take it off the heat, let the grounds settle, and then you can either scoop your coffee or pour it and take a chance of getting some of those grounds in there. That was It was thick, it was strong, it was dark, and it stained.

51:19
It stained if it got it on your clothes. Yeah.

Andrew Woods
51:23
What do you think of it?

Nicole Smith
51:24
Oh I brought some back. Yeah. I got some at my mom's house.

51:29
I make it uh I made it And my stepdad he's the he's another coffee drinker. He couldn't drink it. It was too much for him.

51:35
Yeah. It was too strong. Yeah.

Andrew Woods
51:38
Was it good to have some strong coffee?

Nicole Smith
51:42
It was it was different. It was different. Yeah. It was um it was actually Turkish coffee. Is what the ones that would make it.

Andrew Woods
51:50
That's where it started.

Nicole Smith
51:52
Yeah.

Andrew Woods
51:54
Let's see. Let's see. Oh, and uh your commanding officer. The the names of the year commanding officer for for your

Nicole Smith
52:05
I can't remember.

Andrew Woods
52:07
Well, you you mentioned on your survey here's uh Sergeant Stephen Carter.

Nicole Smith
52:12
Oh, Sergeant First Class Carter. That was um that was my one of my NCOs. Yeah. One of them that I got to work I worked for many NCOs. I a lot of people.

Andrew Woods
52:24
And uh Martin?

Nicole Smith

52:26
Lieutenant Martin. He was our officer in charge of us, the Lieutenant.

Andrew Woods
52:30
Was he uh uh uh NCO before? Yeah.

Nicole Smith
52:35
He was a staff sergeant that got he got tired of the way the some of the officers would react to soldiers and He decided that he had the knowledge and he could change it so he was gonna become an officer, became an officer so he could better lead the soldiers instead of what he saw and what he came up in the army with.

Andrew Woods
53:00
And do you know uh was it like a battlefield commission or officers training school?

Nicole Smith
53:05
Officers training.

Andrew Woods
53:06
Yeah.

Nicole Smith
53:07
He went uh what was that, green to gold? Yeah. And they do that Yeah.

Andrew Woods
53:11
Were have you ever heard of a battlefield commission?

Nicole Smith
53:15
No, only in the history books.

Andrew Woods
53:17
Yeah.

Nicole Smith
53:19
Only in the history books.

Andrew Woods

53:22
And let's see, you you mentioned here uh Command Sergeant Major Butler.

Nicole Smith
53:27
Yes, he was our Sergeant Major for 121 Signal Battalion. Yes Not much to say about him except for he got the job done.

Andrew Woods
53:39
And uh d who was the lieutenant colonel? of the battalion.

Nicole Smith
53:45
You know, for the life of me, I can't remember and I'm embarrassed because I can't remember. I can picture his face. I all night I sat and I was like I can't. I really didn't have a lot of contact with the officers. I really didn't And I purposely chose to ignore most of them. But his name's on here.

Andrew Woods
54:11
Oh. Maybe we can find the

Nicole Smith
54:16
Yeah, it's on here somewhere. Sorry, can I do this? No, right now it's Eric Will.

54:23
And they signed up here in the orange There it is. Garrison. Looks like a Colonel Garrison.

54:33
Oh, I see I feel so bad I forgot his name. He was actually a nice man. There's hm.

Andrew Woods
54:44
Yeah, I w I was looking to see if there was a a signal battalion patch on there.

Nicole Smith
54:50
Um no, we didn't put one on because it's just uh that's that's it.

Andrew Woods
54:53
That's it.

Nicole Smith
54:54

That's what we wore.

Andrew Woods
54:55
That's what you wore.

Nicole Smith
54:56
Mm-hmm. Nope.

Andrew Woods
54:57
You you didn't have uh um the battalion patches.

Nicole Smith
55:01
No, we didn't have a battalion patch at all. I mean that was it. One on each side.

Andrew Woods
55:07
D did any of the battalions wear different patches or did everybody wear the big red one?

Nicole Smith
55:13
Just a everybody wore the big red one. That was big red one. The only ones that had different patches were these that were attached or assigned to us. That's it

Andrew Woods
55:23
Uh d did they have a a special uh award for the combat patch?

Nicole Smith
55:29
Uh they gave us uh certificates that said you're awarded the combat Yeah, it was just a certificate that says that you can now wear the combat patch. You've been authorized it. And then they this this one here is actually the one that was given to me.

55:51
Yeah. They 'cause when they went around they sh the colonel shook everybody's hand and the SAR major and They gave you the certificate and it was inside plastic and they gave you a patch as well. And this is the one that came with my certificate.

Andrew Woods
56:05
Then which arm do you put that on?

Nicole Smith

56:08
I don't know, we got a red big red one on both arms.

Andrew Woods
56:11
Yeah.

Nicole Smith
56:12
No, it was the um right side.

Andrew Woods
56:15
Yeah.

Nicole Smith
56:15
Because we had the flag underneath there.

Andrew Woods
56:20
And uh let's see, uh you you also got the campaign awards.

Nicole Smith
56:27
The Iraqi campaign medal, the global war on terrorism, and there's uh another terrorism award because they gave two. One if you were in the States, and then they gave you another one if you were overse if you were overseas you got both of 'em. So you got those two. Plus the Iraqi campaign medal.

Andrew Woods
56:49
And did they come out with uh I know they've been talking about this, so I don't know what you think about this uh a a award like the combat infantryman badge.

Nicole Smith
56:59
Yeah the combat uh yes the combat action badge the C A B Yeah. I don't want one.

Andrew Woods
57:06
Yeah. What what's your thoughts on that or I think it's just a personally I think it's just another ribbon to add to the uniform that's really

Nicole Smith
57:14

It it's great for those soldiers that actually got out there and were in the middle of the combat and stuff and did do it but they don't get the the um the badge because they're not infantry. Like I think it's great. Right, right.

57:33
But I I think it's just another badge for somebody to sew in their uniform. What's it matter? I mean do you really need to advertise that you've been in combat?

57:45
Do you really need to advertise that you've been in a firefight? And I don't know my dad was in Vietnam and that's the last thing that they advertise. You know most of 'em that I know, they don't talk about it and I actually know quite a few that won't even wear the combat badge.

58:04
They they don't see the point in advertising it.

Andrew Woods
58:07
Do you do you think there's any uh uh carry over from from the Vietnam time to your service in in that attitude?

Nicole Smith
58:21
I think there is. I think there is. Because there's there's a lot of the older NCOs that I've met.

58:28
that half the awards and stuff that they've got they don't wear. Yeah. Just no they just don't wear 'em.

58:34
And I really hate to ask this, but can we take a break? I was gonna

Andrew Woods
58:40
Okay, and uh we're back with uh Sergeant Smith. Uh you wanted to uh speak about the First Division Band some more.

Nicole Smith
58:50
Yes. Um While the first ID ban was in Iraq, not only did they do their traditional duties, but they also um They would ask soldiers to if they anybody who wanted to share any poems that they wrote about Iraq or while they were in Iraq, any songs uh to please share them with them. What they did was they took the the poetry and the words and they put them to music a uh producer in Nashville along with Sony We're gonna create a C D and all this is music that comes from soldiers. They're gonna sell the CD and one hundred percent of the proceeds goes to helping

victims and the soldiers from OIF.

Andrew Woods
59:37
Operation Iraqi Freedom.

Nicole Smith
59:39
Yes. Yes. And they actually have a website where you can keep track of and you can actually hear some if you want to hear some of the songs and see the words and stuff, they have a website that It's the ones that they've produced themselves while they're in it.

Andrew Woods
59:53
Now I saw the band on parade in Wurzburg Um do they also have uh and I saw uh they had a a small combo as well. What what other kind of Oh nationally.

Nicole Smith
01:00:08
Yes, they have a rock band. They plays um all kinds of rock from everywhere, everything from the sixties the seventies to modern day. They've even tried some hip hop, but that just doesn't work as well. But yeah they have They're the ones that are producing the the music?

Andrew Woods
01:00:24
Yeah. And uh what like uh what instruments do they have then?

Nicole Smith
01:00:28
Oh, you name it, they have it. They have um one of the guys in particular, um I don't know what half of 'em are called, but you know, the big drum that you carry.

Andrew Woods
01:00:37
Yeah.

Nicole Smith
01:00:38
He played not only that, but he also played the um the big bass drum. They um bugle. He was one he became one of their buglers for the ceremonies. And uh he played a piano and keyboard and he also played a saxophone Uh most of them were very multi-talented.

Andrew Woods
01:00:58
You'd have to be to get into the band, wouldn't you?

Nicole Smith
01:01:00
Oh yeah, it it's a process to get into the band itself But every single one of 'em play at least two instruments. Wow. That's impressive. And they all sing.

Andrew Woods
01:01:10
Yeah.

Nicole Smith
01:01:10
It might not sound good, but they can sing and they can be in tune.

Andrew Woods
01:01:14
So so that they make a chorus as well

Nicole Smith
01:01:17
Mm-hmm. Yep.

Andrew Woods
01:01:20
Men and women.

Nicole Smith
01:01:21
Men, women, yep. And the other soldiers joined them too.

Andrew Woods
01:01:27
Well you could have a full core as well.

Nicole Smith
01:01:29
In fact they had a soldier from was it quarter calf? I don't remember his name. But um he came up. He was there for about two weeks and he played with the band and he helped write some of the songs and he helped do some of the music for this CD that's doing

Andrew Woods
01:01:50
And uh you were saying uh it was Nashville, do they also uh play country instruments like the slide guitar?

Nicole Smith
01:01:58
Oh yeah, oh yeah. They they they You name it, they probably played it in they sounded really

good too.

Andrew Woods
01:02:06
Uh-huh. But they they also have the traditional brass band.

Nicole Smith
01:02:11
Mm-hmm. Yeah, they have that as well They used that for the ceremonies in the rear. Not too much down there.

01:02:19
Down there it was either the rock band or For ceremonies they would play in Iraq. They would sit up and play the traditional army. That's about it.

Andrew Woods
01:02:35
Any radio programs?

Nicole Smith
01:02:37
No. No. We had uh we got um AFN TV down there, that's it. We didn't have radio Unless you wanted to listen to the Iraqi radio, but you really couldn't understand it, so it was pointless.

Andrew Woods
01:02:50
Oh and also I noticed here you mentioned about uh uh rebuilding and uh sponsoring uh school?

Nicole Smith
01:02:59
Yeah um and Uh one two one sponsored a um girls school and they went out and rebuilt the playground, rebuilt the school and um a bunch of the churches from the soldiers, their churches and families back home would send notebooks, pens, paper, pencils to help them get chalk chalkboards, you know, the the spray paint that you can spray on the wall and turn it into a chalkboard. They got a whole bunch of that stuff and revamped the whole school. Clothes for the girls.

01:03:37
And but very few people could go out and actually work on it because they were It was it was a Muslim school. So it took them a long time to adjust to having the the males there, the male Americans. And uh They would only send out a few of the females on a regular basis because the teachers who were females wouldn't talk to the males.

01:04:03
They had to have a female there that was present. Even if the translator was male, they still

wanted they were more comfortable with the female present.

Andrew Woods
01:04:11
Yeah. Is this something that you did personally?

Nicole Smith
01:04:15
No, I didn't get a chance to go.

Andrew Woods
01:04:21
Or or were there any other activities that you you got to participate in because you're a woman that uh male soldiers couldn't have?

Nicole Smith
01:04:29
No That was pretty much it.

Andrew Woods
01:05:02
Carrie, because she had a lot of questions.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:05:05
Yeah, thank you. and um eventually found its way here to the First Division Museum.

Nicole Smith
01:05:17
I wanted to ask you how what prompted you to make this quilt? I always planned on making one when I went down there. I figured I was gonna have a lot of time with my hands at nights doing nothing, so I was gonna sit and hand sew a quilt. But then I ended up working at the MWR and that was a busy job.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:05:37
The NWR? MWR. MWR.

01:05:40
Okay. Which is I'm sorry, uh morale, welfare and recreation. Okay.

01:05:45
Okay, I heard you correctly. Um so have you did you before you went to Iraq, did you sew things, make a quilt before that? Mm-hmm Made lots of quotes.

01:05:54

Okay. Made a yeah, a lot of 'em. Um, did anyone teach you how to do this or did you learn from anyone in your family?

Nicole Smith
01:06:02
Just kinda grew up doing it. Okay. My mom did it um as a survival thing growing up and you just kinda pick it up and just d you do it, you run with it.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:06:14
So you wanted to do it in your free time. Um did it have any other significance to you as a soldier there in Iraq to be making this quilt?

Nicole Smith
01:06:25
Yeah, it um yes it did as a matter of fact. It's a record of every single unit that was there And a lot of the friends and people that I met that not only changed my life, but I helped with theirs have signed this thing. I don't know how to explain it. It just it just it's a record of history Mm-hmm. It's it's a record of my time there and the people that I met and came across and that'd be the best way to explain it.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:07:06
You mentioned um in included in the donation was a binder which you incredibly well just beautifully documented every step of the process and basically the whole story from start to finish and even thereafter in in the quilt making process And I think you had mentioned in there that you you even felt it was a memorial to those that you served. Is that is that correct?

Nicole Smith
01:07:31
Did I an a memori uh a small memorial to those that we lost There's a few people that signed this that aren't here anymore. And one of them, I I can't remember exactly where, but there's an upside-down cross. next to it looks I think it was supposed to be right side up but it looks more like a a plus sign okay of a soldier that had passed away not long after he'd signed this thing. The the sheet

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:08:02
You know, I I think in the binder you also um pardon me mentioned that, you know, in addition to it being a memorial, it you wanted to show the human side. of the soldiers that served in Iraq. Can you tell us a little bit more about that?

Nicole Smith
01:08:18

We don't all just carry weapons and kill people. Contrary to what the uh movies say, like we discussed we were saying yesterday, Rambo. Right.

01:08:29
It's not all about that. I mean you spend a lot of time sitting and waiting for somebody to give you your orders. And we have a humanitarian side to us.

01:08:40
We don't spend all of our time in Iraq killing Iraqis or the the insurgents. We spent a lot of time helping kids, helping rebuild the cities, educate in Most people don't think about that, especially the younger kids. They don't think about that.

01:08:58
They just think about you know the weapons and the killing and the fun and all that. But I'm a woman first and I like to quote, I like to do stuff like this, and I'm a soldier second. And it just It shows people that we are, you know, we're not just soldiers.

01:09:17
We're multi-talented. And we can give as much as take.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:09:24
You know, um where did where did you receive or how did you get um the materials that you used to make this quilt? My mother sent them to me.

Nicole Smith
01:09:33
Most of this is leftovers from she makes her own smocks. She's in the in the medical field. Okay.

01:09:40
A lot of these are leftovers from that. Like this one, this was a one of her smocks. Actually a lot of them were her smocks.

01:09:50
Um let me see this one. I actually have a dress that was made out of this one when I was a little girl and she used it for to do make something else and she sent me the scraps. I was like thanks mom you could have asked me before you cut my dress out.

01:10:05
And oh like this one right here. The I have um my stepdad's grandchildren. Um he has a twins.

01:10:17
This was used to make a blanket for them It's pretty. And it's just leftovers that do a scent. This was used for a quilt for somebody.

01:10:28
Mom had used it. This was used for another one for a quilt for someone. Okay.

01:10:34
It just is

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:10:38
You had brought um two of the patterns with you, I think you mentioned yesterday, right? The American um the American flag pattern and there was uh the blue pattern on there. I think you said did you bring that with you originally or no

Nicole Smith
01:10:52
Oh yeah, I bought yeah I hand carried these 'cause I found them on the internet. Mm-hmm. Yeah, the ones in the center piece the centerpieces, yeah.

01:11:03
I had actually um actually I found this on the internet and the blue stuff, I actually got this in Germany. I thought it was so pretty and I used it to make a quilt for my best friend. Mm-hmm.

01:11:14
Just I just got a small piece of it and I took it with me. Because originally I wasn't gonna make a huge blanket. I was just gonna make like a small, like baby blanket size.

01:11:23
Mm-hmm But um yeah, as you can see we ended up with this. It's beautiful. I actually slept underneath this thing too.

01:11:32
Did you? Yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:11:33
Mm-hmm.

Nicole Smith
01:11:33
I'd sit in my uh on my bed and sew the patches on and I'd actually fall asleep I'd be watching TV with my headphones on sewing and I fall asleep. So I'd curl up underneath it and wake up in the morning and say, wow, I actually fell asleep. Yeah, there we go.

01:11:50
There's the band. Kruchek, that's the name of the the first ID band. Yeah, that was our name.

01:12:01

Yeah. I just remembered that. I couldn't it's difficult to pronounce.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:12:08
How about that the red sheet?

Nicole Smith
01:12:12
Martha Stewart. Martha Stewart, I told my mom to go I sent her the first ID patch And I say, Mom, I need a red that's gonna match the big red one patch because I wanted it to be the big red one colors. And as you can tell it doesn't match.

01:12:28
It still looks really nice. Yes. And it's great because it doesn't fade.

01:12:33
I've my mom washed it and she dried it and she washed it and she dried it a couple times to make sure that it was and it hasn't faded. It's never been washed. The quilt itself?

01:12:48
Yeah, it's never. Right I think you said that some of them were you thought were already fading. Yeah, some of 'em and th this sheet is so old that it's like half it's starting to fact there's a hole that I didn't get.

01:13:04
I patched most of 'em as best I could. Mm-hmm. So how long did it take you to make this?

01:13:14
Six months, um total of four hundred and sixty hours. Wow How often did you work on it? Um, well I had Fridays off.

01:13:23
Uhhuh. So I would get off work on Thursday night, about one, two o'clock in the morning and I would go upstairs and I'd start sewing or piecing together or I'd work on it pretty much most of the day Friday and then I'd go back on to the hooch and pass out. Until I had to go to work the next day.

01:13:41
I thought it was pretty relaxing to work on the quilts Um, it was when nobody was knocking on the door to I used to have to lock myself in the room. Really? So yeah.

01:13:57
wanna take it out and and it was okay when they come up to help but if they just wanted to come up to chat it's like I was busy and I was concentrating and Yeah, it was my way to relax and I couldn't relax when somebody was answering asking me a bunch of stuff.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:14:15
So when did people um Cause I noticed that some of them are signed on with a marker and some of them are embroidered. When did people start to sign? How did tell me about how people started to sign it or how you did you asked

Nicole Smith
01:14:28
Well it it started by I laid this sheet out on two pa on two tables and asked people to sign it. I was like it's gonna go to somebody, you know when right before we leave here. You know, whoever at the MWR was the one that helped the soldiers most and which was the NCOIC.

01:14:47
But in all reality, I initially planned on using it for the quilt. But I didn't want to tell anybody about the quilt until I at least got enough of it finished. Started pinning them up, had the pattern pinned up on this cardboard, it stretched.

01:15:03
I mean you see how big this was. Imagine it knocked sewn together, it was twice that size. It's a quote.

01:15:11
Oh, cool. And at the same time, um, you know, I have all the units have them cut out on a little piece of paper. And I gotta figure out how to place these units, oneness embroidered.

01:15:24
And a soldier came in one day and said, Well won't you just pick a color? I was like, you know what? What unit are you in?

01:15:30
He told me I said, pick a color Pick a square. He picked a square. I said, alright, that's the square.

01:15:35
Pin it onto it and stick it back up there. Mm-hmm. So it took about two, three weeks to finish all of it.

01:15:40
Okay. And alright Just got down to the last few and stuck 'em up there ourselves. But we missed a few units.

01:15:47
Okay. Cause the um G six, the generals staff, the communications department, that's who I ended up getting this list from, which is in the back of the book, wherever the book's at. But it's in the back of that book.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:16:02
Oh, the book's right behind you in case you wanted to use it or refer to it.

Nicole Smith
01:16:06
Yes, because I want to show this. Schematic. It took a long time to get this It took a long time.

01:16:17
Those are all the units. And I had to figure out how to break them down. Well when everybody was just pace was when I decided to just Pick a square.

01:16:26
Then I had to keep track. So I did a pencil drawing. So every time we put one up, I'd write down where it went.

01:16:33
I was like, you know, this is not gonna work very well. So I went and I did an Excel spreadsheet. And I I filled them in all down here and then I typed them all in and then I press a click and did them alphanumeric and So that way you could go down and you could say, oh there's my unit.

01:16:51
Okay, where's it at? Row one um column twelve. Bam, there it is.

Andrew Woods
01:16:57
Oh I love seeing that post

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:16:59
Now are you are you just a naturally do you like organization? How what prompted you because that binder is fantastic. I mean everything is documented.

Nicole Smith
01:17:09
Okay. I think it's important Like my dad was in Vietnam. He brought things back, he brought pictures back, and he didn't do any of the things at the bottom that you know, the labels that tell.

01:17:20
My aunt did all that stuff. Yeah, the captions. My aunt did all that stuff.

01:17:24
And if she wouldn't have done that, then like me and my brother, when we go through the photo, we wouldn't know about it. Or she'd write it on the back of it. And I just I like to know where things are at and I wanna remember this when I'm old and have Alzheimer's and you

know, when my grandkids come and they look like, You did this?

01:17:44
Like, Yeah, I did that. That and um I just I don't know just wanted to keep a piece of it because I knew I wasn't gonna keep the blanket and I wanted to keep some of the memories for it

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:17:58
Now tell tell us more about that. Um what because you you wound up, you know, selling it for charity. Tell us about that story.

Nicole Smith
01:18:06
They were asking for donations for the First ID Foundation. And me and Steph Sarn Robinson were we we were debating. He would pick some charities and I would pick some and we'd discuss them and You know, we really I wanted something that was going to go towards not Iraq.

01:18:24
I wanted it to go towards soldiers And they were doing the asking for donations and I was like, you know what? That's a really good cause. And I got online and uh I called back to uh Bluebell, Pennsylvania.

01:18:36
Mm-hmm. Ironically enough, and I'm from Pennsylvania. Talked to the ladies back there and um found out a little bit about the organization.

01:18:45
And here they actually have a um foundations it's but it's part of the foundation but it's strictly for the education of the children of our fallen soldiers. And I was like, wow, that's pretty cool. You know, that that'd be something to to give something to.

01:19:02
And I told them about the quilt, I sent them some pictures and they're like, wow, that's a really good idea. That would be awesome And it went from there. And then what was it like it was like a week before the auction ended.

01:19:16
Because I said it to end on September 11th, 2004. Okay. And uh It was I I'm getting emails from eBay.

01:19:25
People are like, I saw it on Fox News, I saw it on CNN, and I was like Okay, I didn't know that.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

01:19:32
So go ahead. Go on, sorry.

Nicole Smith
01:19:33
They had taken my interview that the Public Affairs Office had done and they sent it out to all these places. Okay. And they had sent a copy to the foundation and they sent it to They're count their people that are part of the Bro Foundation.

01:19:48
And they did the same with the the radio interview and stuff and I was like, wow, that's pretty cool. Mm-hmm. So Didn't see all the press coming, did you?

01:19:59
No, I didn't. Not at all. I didn't even know about half of it. There's like quilting magazines that it's supposed to be in too and I haven't seen half of everything.

01:20:09
It's amazing.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:20:10
So no, you decided to sell it on eBay to raise the money for charity. What means you what made you think to do that

Nicole Smith
01:20:18
'Cause I didn't know where else to sell it. I was in Iraq. I didn't know what else to and I figure, well eBay is like across the United States.

01:20:25
Everybody goes to to eBay. Mm-hmm. You know, or somebody knows somebody that knows somebody that has an eBay account.

01:20:31
Mm-hmm. That and um You can set it up that the money would automatically go it w I wouldn't have had to touch the money at all. It would have went went to the account and went right to the foundation.

01:20:42
Perfect, yeah. But I ended up Having to cash all the checks, okay. And then writing out a check and sending it to the foundation.

01:20:50
Mm-hmm. Cause uh eBay was not very cooperative.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:20:54
Okay.

Nicole Smith
01:20:55
Very cooperative at all when it came time for the sale of it and everything. Because um yeah, they just weren't They actually were gonna um charge taxes for the money for the quilt because it had made so much and because of where I was from, Pennsylvania. And I thought it was ridiculous and I argued with them.

01:21:16
Yeah. I I literally argued with them and that's why I was like, nope, just send the text to my mom, I'll be home. I cashed 'em.

01:21:23
Right. Well my mom deposited them to an account that we had opened. had a certified check made and sent it right down to the first ID f foundation.

01:21:33
I called eBay and I told 'em what I did. And they were like, you can't do that. You need to give us ninety five hundred dollars so we can send it to him.

01:21:40
I'm like, Too late I already sent it to him. What? He said, yep, I s I took a photo um Well, uh I had the lady at the bank take a photo copy avoid it of the check and then you know a copy um um receipts from the post office to send in the check and send it to them and then like okay so they voided the account but I was not allowed to do anything on eBay for a year.

01:22:03
They banned me for a year. Huh? So you had to do what you had to do to make sure it got done correctly.

Andrew Woods
01:22:07
Yeah.

Nicole Smith
01:22:11
Yeah. Yeah. It it It was it was really a mess and slightly confusing and it all happened so fast and I don't think that they really expected it to go for that much either.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:22:24
Yeah, so it sold for nine thousand five hundred. That's impressive So tell us more about um you

know, because there's there's documentation in the binder, but tell us more about um you posted it on I think you said When did you post it on eBay? Um when did I post it?

Nicole Smith
01:22:42
I'll tell you in a minute. I think it's in here. I know the auction ended on the uh

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:22:47
November eleventh of two thousand and four, right? Veterans Day. Yeah. All right.

Nicole Smith
01:22:59
Can't see it. I don't remember the day that I posted it. Okay.

01:23:04
I think it was I don't remember. It was two weeks prior to the no, it was thirty days. Okay.

01:23:09
I think it was thirty days because I that's what I did the auction for was thirty days. Which turned out to be a good thing. Okay.

01:23:15
Because It gave people more time to actually oh hey it's there. But it was like a week before that that it hit the news and stuff and then people started bidding on it. Mm-hmm.

01:23:24
So it was actually perfect timing

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:23:27
So who are some of the people who bid on it and who eventually wound up buying it, winning the ear?

Nicole Smith
01:23:33
I don't know who all bid on it because I don't show you oh I couldn't see by the time I got to it I couldn't see who had bid on it. I was watching, but I really wasn't keeping track. I just kept track of who won it. The town of Sonora, Texas.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:23:46
Okay.

Nicole Smith
01:23:46

They won it. Oh, they they bit $9,500 They were there at the very last second. They hit enter like right before it ended.

01:23:54

Uh-huh. And it hit and they got it. Now when you say the town, was it um twenty four people?

01:24:00

Twenty four people. Yes. And I don't think it's in here, no. But I have it on my computer at home.

01:24:06

Um the list and names of every single person that and how much they can send for the donation. Great. Yeah, 'cause I did individual receipts for 'em and so they could for the taxes.

01:24:23

Then I hand delivered it to him too. Did you? Uh took my mom and we flew down for the weekend and took it down to him.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

01:24:30

I bet that was very special.

Nicole Smith

01:24:32

It was. It was Breathtaking. Tell me about it.

01:24:39

Oh, we just we flew down and drove up to meet them and they had a uh Oh what do you call that? Um I call it a bazaar like a flea market, but um a crash so home the people made their homemade stuff and selling it and showed up and with a quote Only a few people knew we were gonna were expecting us. The rest of them didn't have a clue and they had the news there waiting for us, so we went in and laid it out and they had a Miss Oh she was a beauty queen.

01:25:15

I forget which part of Texas she was from, but they had her there to meet us and greet us and that was pretty neat. Never talked to a beauty queen in a gown before. But Yeah.

01:25:32

And that was they took us around, showed us the town and they displayed the quilt. They decided they were gonna display it at each business of people that had donated money. So They had a frame made for it, wow, to hang it up.

01:25:49

And then we left. So what did they do with the quilt from there? Um, they wanted to resell it after they had shown it around town and stuff.

01:26:00
Mm-hmm. But I guess they didn't I think they I don't know if they tried to sell it. Um they emailed me and asked me my suggestion what I w thought should be done with it.

01:26:13
I was like, Can you give it back to me? No, I told I didn't you know, it didn't matter what they did to it. Mm-hmm.

01:26:20
You know, I the could sell it, give it to the foundation, pick somebody to keep it, you know, fold it up, stuff it in the attic and then then I heard that they actually did give it back to the foundation. Mm-hmm So that was that made me happy. That was it was cool.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:26:35
And actually that's um I think at the Borough reunion this year, the first the big red one reunion in Washington DC Um, that's when the foundation gave it handed over to us to keep at the museum and preserve it.

Nicole Smith
01:26:48
Yep, that's what I heard. That was cool I know Major Pain came and found me. When he came back to factor Germany, he got a hold of me and let me know.

01:26:58
He was so excited too. He says it was so awesome He said it was so cool because he was one that got to see it in the stages as it was coming along. He saw the first stage when it was the front was all sewed together except for the center square.

01:27:13
Mm-hmm. And General T C come down and look at it and stuff and Major Payne he'd come in and take a look at it and he was Captain Payne at the time But yeah, it he said it was really w it was strange but it was really awesome to see the finished product in the States instead of in Iraq. It was almost like it was a merge between, you know, it brought back memories of Iraq and feeling like you're there, but yet you're in the United States.

01:27:43
If it makes sense. It's And it does the same with me just looking at it. It's like I see little stuff on there and I'm getting flashbacks of little memories and stuff of of Iraq.

01:27:59
It's different. It's strange. It's almost like I never left, but yet I'm not there anymore.

01:28:05
And the smell, I can smell I react on it. Yeah? Yes.

01:28:09
I can smell the the the dirt and all that from it. Just the air.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:28:16
Now included with the donation, you included um lavender, right?

Nicole Smith
01:28:21
Yes. Because of that? Um yeah, I didn't want it with the traveling and stuff, the bag that it was in the bag wasn't waterproof.

01:28:29
It was just a big flight canvas bag. So I took some um French lavender that I buy in uh well used to buy in uh Rothenburg, Germany. And I stuffed it in between to keep the smell of the quilt smelling good instead of like dirt.

01:28:48
I actually did clean it once, but I used um just a washcloth and I'd rinse it just with warm water, any spots that were on it and such.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:29:01
And you used um you you actually used cotton, right? That yes. How did how did that work? Tell me about that. And yeah, I think you cleaned the cotton.

Nicole Smith
01:29:11
That was a nightmare. I asked um Ayub, that's the gentleman that did all the embroidery. He I I asked him for some stuffing for it.

01:29:21
He brings me in these bags their um burlet bags stuffed with fresh raw cotton. Twigs, seeds, and it still had um just the the the oil in it. And it was It was just and there was enough oil that when you would like pick it up and drop it, it was like touching your hand to your car oil.

01:29:45
And lifted it up, it had enough oil. I was like, there's no way I can put this in there. How am I gonna do this?

01:29:51
It's just like big just bottles of it. So I took it I held it over a plastic bag. I took a hairbrush and it just well I shook it and then I would go like this and I would comb it and then I'd pull it off of the hairbrush and tow it in the bag keep at it until it was and then I took it in and I washed it first with tap water.

01:30:15
Which the tap water over there is really disgusting. It comes it's brown and But I started washing it first and then I had to start using the bottle of water because then it started to smell. Mm-hmm.

01:30:25
But I used ended up using bottled water and Dawn dish detergent. Okay to hopefully get some of the oil out which it worked really good. And it made it smell good too.

01:30:34
And it cleaned it of any bugs and stuff that was in there. Mm-hmm That was interesting. I'd wash it, I'd sit you know, just wash it and then I'd had towels.

01:30:42
I'd laid it out. It didn't take long for it to dry in that heat. Dry it and then just stuff it in a clean bag.

01:30:48
I had um Pillowcases, stuff it in pillowcases. Cause I took um two and a half sheets, the Iraqi bed sheets. Okay.

01:30:57
I bought 'em, washed them, sewed 'em together, made this huge pocket and uh Say this is the sheet that I that uh the big pocket. Mm-hmm. I'd sew it this way, leaving a hole.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:31:10
Okay.

Nicole Smith
01:31:10
Stuff it with the cotton and then I wouldn't close it But I would zigzag back and then zigzag back. Okay. And then come up and then I would sew this way, leaving a hole at this end.

01:31:24
Mm-hmm. Stuff it. Mm-hmm.

01:31:26
Zig you know, zigzag, zigzag, and then That's how I did the whole thing. That's why it's kinda lumpy in places and stuff it and yeah. But it's really interesting.

01:31:38
It was to then I sewed it to the back of this to the back piece and then I turned it I sewed around the edges and then I f you sew it. And then because I didn't have binding and stuff For some reason I I kept asking my mom to send it, but I think she forgot. But that's all right.

01:32:03
I still may do. But you sew it, you got all your frayed edges. I took and I folded it in half like this again and then sewed it.

01:32:11
So that way there's a chance it would reinforce the corners and hopefully 'Cause it is kinda heavy. It is kinda heavy. I didn't want it to rip open.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:32:21
You know, I think yesterday you mentioned One of the sheets that you used was um something you were you were issued at Ford Hood, right?

Nicole Smith
01:32:27
Yes. The white sheet on the back is my first issued sheet from Fort Hood. Supposed to turn 'em in, but I kept 'em.

01:32:36
I went and bought a sheet just because I liked it. It was nice and soft and it was worn worn in, you know, broke in. And it still is too And that was in 1990, 1995.

01:32:48
Wow.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:32:51
So now you also received some other help in making this quote, right? You mentioned that there was a a tailor Mm-hmm.

Nicole Smith
01:32:57
That you worked with? Yep, I hope. He did all the embroidery for it.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:33:01
Mhm.

Nicole Smith
01:33:02
He uh he charged me up until he found out what the blanket was four and then he quit charging me and he did all the embroidery for free. Um he actually taught me how to use the machine, the sewing machine over there. Cause it's Some of the things are backwards than what we're used to using on the machines.

01:33:20

And the soldiers help too. Mm-hmm, you know They got to pick the squares they wanted the things embroidered on. The patches.

01:33:27
I wouldn't have the patches if the soldiers wanted giving them to me. Off their uniforms, right?

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:33:31
Mm-hmm. Yeah.

Nicole Smith
01:33:31
Um the word of mouth that spread. And then one in particular the um Soldier bugged his first arm until his first arm came down and looked at it and signed it. It's that story is in here too. I wrote it down on the picture next to the patch.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:33:47
So now um can you tell me a little bit more about the tailor that you worked with? I you? Yeah, because he he was also he he did a lot of work for Americans, I remember you saying he would make suits, he would

Nicole Smith
01:34:00
you know, he sewed our patches on, which he got paid from the army for that. But his ex other income was he would make suits for the guys and dresses and suits for the ladies, gowns. Um you wanted it, he could do it.

01:34:15
uh he was just absolute and he loved soldiers. He had pictures all over the wall. He ha he'd take 'em home too, he'd take 'em to his house.

01:34:23
He had pictures in his house of soldiers, him standing next to the soldiers. It was He loved American soldiers. We were good for him.

01:34:32
He never had such a good income until we came and he started working for us. It was it was awesome.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:34:42
Did he um did he see the finished product or no?

Nicole Smith
01:34:48

Do you he got he got to see some of it but not the completed completed. He was um he was assassinated before that was completely finished Can you tell me about that story? Um he was um yeah him and his wife hand And the little boy that worked for him, he's like twelve, thirteen, nine, I can't remember exactly.

01:35:15
But uh they were on their way home, got forced off the road and because they worked for the Americans, whatever they did, that particular part of their anatomy was separated from their their body. And they were left to Bleed to death on the side of the road. But yeah, it was sad.

01:35:39
It was very sad. He was a good man. He really was.

01:35:43
He did a lot for the soldiers. He really did a lot for us. He was one of the good guys.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:35:53
Can you tell me a little bit more about um the people who signed the quilt. I I know that yesterday when we were talking about it, you had a lot of stories about a lot of the different signatures and patches that are on there. Um I mean I don't I don't know if that we want to share all of them, but maybe you can at least pick a a good handful and and tell us about, you know, some of these people and the effect they had on you even.

Nicole Smith
01:36:22
Let's see. Where's it at? I'm gonna try to take you too while I'm at it This one.

01:36:36
This one is uh Lieutenant Colonel Weaver and I do not know how to say the lady's name. She was an Iraqi. Um she worked for Lieutenant Colonel Weaver.

01:36:47
It was what they it was the Iraqi Assistance Center in Baghdad. Their whole purpose was to help bring together all the um the Red Cross, the um the Humane Society for the Animals, um, the Handicap Society and all the organizations like that into integrate Iraq into using them system those systems and to help them learn how to use the systems to help the people and where to go to get the stuff that they need. But this lady, she was during um Saddam's Sajim she was a textile owner.

01:37:28
Her husband was the front you know, because women couldn't do stuff like that at that time. And since Saddam is no longer part of it, she's still a textile owner of the business, but she also helps and she's a translator and helps with this organization. Very wonderful lady.

01:37:46
Very wonderful. She uh yeah, I can't say that. Definitely can't say that name

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:37:54
Well I thought it was very interesting. I think that's the woman you said that after Saddam's regime she was able to really become an advocate for women's rights in Iraq.

Nicole Smith
01:38:04
She is For her personally to help women to become independent and free in their society is what she does. She likes to do. Let's see what else.

01:38:18
Oh, here's a local one for you guys. The Chicago, Illinois, Bravo Company first the first 106 Aviation. These guys used to come to the MWR all the time.

01:38:34
They'd visit and uh they'd fight the CD around sometimes and sometimes they'd fight other people around But they used to come up and stop in to visit just to say hi. It's like, hey, what's up today? Anything new going on?

01:38:51
And seriously, that's what they would do Let's see what else. Oh, here's one They signed the back as well. Second of the 108th Infantry out of New York.

01:39:08
Police department police officers and firefighters from New York that were actually there on 9-11 that lost friends, family, loved ones, comrades in the 911. And I just I this this one this is my favorite patch This is my favorite because what they went through and they signed the back as well. They got some cute little things on the back.

01:39:33
Um but in the fact of where they were at and what they were doing at the time. It was just it it it's impressive because they could have quit but they didn't. They still do what they they still do what they you know, sign up to do and they still do what they feel they have to do. Yeah.

01:39:53
And it it takes heart. It takes heart.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:39:57
Time to think what else. Um I know that you there was some things that I can think of offhand was Hanner? You're talking about Hanner? Oh. I thought it was interesting this this his story even, you know.

Nicole Smith
01:40:11
Where's oh shoot I should have marked them with like a piece of red tape or something. Staff saw an Hanner. was in Iraq.

01:40:24
Well, he went to Afghanistan with the hundred and first when they first went in. before we even knew they were going in. Mm-hmm.

01:40:33
And he was in the hundred first when they first went into Iraq and they were he was also and then he went came to the first ID, mm-hmm headquarters first ID when Um we went in to Iraq. His nickname is um killer. He's actually a sniper.

01:40:57
That's what he did. If um you'll find him in a lot of the magazines and stuff during the training. Um he spent some time in um Africa as well doing some training.

01:41:07
But this this was this was he'd been there so much that his wife divorced him and he made a decision Uh he's getting out of the military now. He he actually he trains Rangers in Germany right now, but he made the decision to get out and Um he wants to see his daughter grow up. Yeah.

01:41:28
He's good at what he does, but his choice is life. To life instead of taking alive anymore. It's to give lives.

01:41:39
But he's a he's I stay in touch with him. He's one of the ones that I'm actually became really close to down there. So he used to he used to come up every time they went out 'cause he was one that h they he went out on the dangerous convoys and the dangerous runs and stuff and once I got to know him this flight I worried about everybody that went.

01:41:59
But the people that I got really close to I really worried about and he knew. So you know, no matter how tired he were when he got back he would always come up, you know, and just to come up to say hi and my stomach's growling. But oh there was one day they were um he was actually walking from where he where they lived at on the fob over to us and mortars came in, two of 'em.

01:42:25
And they landed. He couldn't hear for a week. Him and the other two guys that were with him.

01:42:29
Wow. Because the mortars landed so close They actually um one of the guys got hit with a piece of the shrapnel but it just bounced off of him because he had his plates on and stuff so it didn't hurt him any. Yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:42:44
If y if you don't mind, I I'd like to talk just about a few more of the patches. And then and then we'll and then I'll kind of because I know you probably want to take another break. Um, I'll ask just a few more questions.

01:42:54
But I one of the things you were mentioning yesterday about the Red Cross, the American Red Cross, and there, you know, I think they signed it even. Yes, they did. And they had to sign the side big effect on you guys there.

01:43:06
Mm-hmm.

Nicole Smith
01:43:08
They sign the front and the back. See they rotated every six months. Or every uh no, I'm sorry, every three months they would rotate.

01:43:16
Three to six? I can't always remember. But yeah, there's And there's a picture of them sitting in there during one of the shows.

01:43:24
But uh they played a small part in a big way. 'Cause example, um there was a hurricane that came through um Alabama. If these those Alabama soldiers that were down there, if the Red Cross wouldn't have been there There's no way that they would have been able to I'm I'm sure that there would have been, but the easiest way was the Red Cross was getting messages to pass on to them so that they find out how their family members are doing, if they're okay.

01:43:55
And and that was a big part I mean, that's part of like the morale. Yeah. So and they they would get a lot of stuff like toothpaste, toothbrush.

01:44:05
We get convoys in and if they got there too late they'd have to stay. Mm-hmm. They knew they could always go to the Red Cross and they had an overnight, you know, toothpaste, toothbrush, mouthwash, you name it, they had it and they can at least clean up and get a shower for the night How about the Iraqi flag that's on there?

01:44:26
It's just the Iraqi flag. Well it's upside down right there. This is the first um officially elected governor, the governor of Diala.

01:44:38
And I'm not even gonna attempt to say his name. Well, I think it's Abdullah Rashid. Doctor Abdul.

01:44:45
Mm-hmm. And excuse me, this is the um governor of Takrait. He signed it there.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:44:52
Mm-hmm.

Andrew Woods
01:44:56
Uh you were talking about a hurricane. Um was that uh Charlie or or which which hurricane? Because I know my folks in Florida got hit by one of those

Nicole Smith
01:45:08
No, it was a tornado. Was it a tornado or was it a hurricane? I can't remember now.

Andrew Woods
01:45:13
Was it in Mobile or or further north?

Nicole Smith
01:45:17
Yeah, it was in Mobile. Probably a hurricane in that area. And we were so isolated that everything on the news was Iraq, Iraq, Iraq, Iraq, Iraq.

01:45:28
We only got bits and pieces of little other stuff here and there. And they we got three channels down there. Yeah.

01:45:34
It was AFN, but we only got like three channels that we could watch. Fox, CNN, and Oh yeah, AFN, regular AFN channel. Which was all news, pretty much.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:45:49
You know there's there's two things on the blanket that I know that somebody might not know about. There's I will I and sit for big uh big red one, wasn't it? It was well no it wasn't that. It was um She with the rash?

Nicole Smith
01:46:02
Oh, that one that was Sarn Hanner. Yeah, he um okay, the First Armantury Division has a nickname by uh some of the soldiers, they call it the big red rash. And he just so happened to sign it the big red rash.

01:46:16
Uh-huh. Well, his Sarah Major saw it and made him change it It he didn't scratch it out though. He just put in parentheses one.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:46:26
That was and that the peace sign by your hand, somebody built something else there, right?

Nicole Smith
01:46:32
Yeah, one of the Iraqis had put um F U C K U S A. And I wanted to cover it up and I didn't know how to cover it up and I couldn't get it off and so I put a big old peace symbol around it I think you can still read it too. It's in there. Another cute story.

01:46:52
If somebody had a crush on you? Yeah, you would have to go there, wouldn't you? Yeah, one of the um one of the Iraqis that worked upstairs.

01:47:02
He uh always telling me he loved me and he was gonna marry me and I was so cute and you know, blonde hair, blue eyes. You know they got a thing for that I guess. But um so he put a heart on there and put um Sam loves Smith.

01:47:20
I was like, uh uh. So I scratched out and put Love's USA. I changed it.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:47:30
And your signature is on there as well, in the in the pink square in the corner, I believe.

Nicole Smith
01:47:33
Mm-hmm. I got it on the back and I got it on the front. Mm-hmm.

01:47:37
Pink 'cause I like pink. It's feminine. Very feminine.

01:47:41
I used to carry in my pocket a little pink pouch with lavender in it. Since everything was dull and there's just dull it added color to it. And Batiste signed it as well.

01:47:53
He finally he dragged him down. General Batiste. He was the last one to sign it, as a matter of fact.

01:47:58
The last of the generals. We have General Batiste and his staff General Morgan and some of his staff and um General Munt and some of his people signed it But mostly um General Batiste uh most everybody on his staff signed right around in where he was and Sergeant Major McCarty. All the top for the first infantry division.

01:48:26
That's great. All the the top people. I know that was that was uh General Morgan he used to come into the MWR well the one time he came in and he was like Sarah Smith.

01:48:41
We didn't know who it was. Didn't didn't have a clue. We just hear this person screaming my name.

01:48:45
So I'm running out and the E7 was in the office with me. We're watching the auction going on. He comes out too and we're like Oh, and we're about to holler, you know, attention and he's like he's like, what where's what what's that?

01:48:58
What's how's it going? How's it going? It's like everything's fine.

01:49:01
I said, you well, we're sitting and watching the auction, you want to come back in and see it? Yeah, yeah, yeah, I wanna see, you wanna see, you know. He was hyper and I I say high strong in a good in a good way.

01:49:10
So we went back in the office and the E seven he's still, you know, standing up and Yeah. He's like, Sit, relax, relax, you know. He's still standing up.

01:49:19
He just left him standing there for a little bit. And I'm talking to him and he's like, Well, where's the blanket? 'Cause he didn't see the blanket when it was completely finished either.

01:49:26
I because the buttons was the last thing I did. And uh pulled it out and he's looking at it and you know, I mean he's like trying to read as much as you can I guess. But um it was it was just funny because it was so informal.

01:49:43

It wasn't, you know, proper and all that stuff. Mm-hmm. So it was cool.

01:49:49
But the fact that he came into the MWR and specifically asked for me and specifically asked about this and wanted to see where it was. And that was the day it hit five thousand. On uh eBay.

01:50:03
Now how many people signed it total? Um, I'm guessing about twenty five hundred. Okay.

01:50:09
Cause um Yeah, we tried to count it, but it was couldn't exactly figure out how to count it without missing any.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:50:18
Now you said the quilt attracted a lot of attention and you I mean it really mm connected you to a lot of people there.

Nicole Smith
01:50:25
Oh yeah. A lot of these people I would have never met if it wouldn't have been for this. Mm-hmm.

01:50:29
It really wouldn't have been Um Colonel Bray. He's the um first first column. Oh I see.

01:50:38
He got me out of Europe. He's the one who got me my assignment to leave Germany. Um I cut his patch off of him.

01:50:45
But he had to ask the general first to make sure it was okay. Cut his patch off. And uh I had my needle and thread right there and I sewed it right on.

01:50:53
So it was a first time green and um Major Bray

Andrew Woods
01:50:57
Yeah, that's a different kind of s shoulder patch, isn't it?

Nicole Smith
01:51:01
Mm-hmm. It's 38th PSP. They weren't uh oh yeah you're right. There was they're still part of First ID, but it's the 38th PSP

Andrew Woods
01:51:12
It's not doesn't have the same shield shape.

Nicole Smith
01:51:15
No, it doesn't at all. You're right. Think about that.

01:51:22
As the Air Force. Those are the ones that um Actually, yeah, these are the ones that called in the strikes to bomb the bridge right there outside our fob. Wow.

01:51:36
Did the Marines Wait, they're on here too.

Andrew Woods
01:51:39
Um Forward operating base.

Nicole Smith
01:51:41
That's the Navy. Um one of the marine groups came in and had to rebuild. The bridge that we blew up.

01:51:49
That these guys blew up. The uh was it down? Shoot, I can't remember, but they they were all gone, so I didn't I couldn't get 'em to sign any of it.

01:52:01
Hm. But now here's a unit that we missed. Um the nineteen oh eighth Med Detachment Combat Stress Control.

01:52:10
They were actually attached to one of the active duty units but even though they were attached, I still, you know, it's like take a marker and go ahead and fill it in because I was still wanted to show that they were there and how many were there. Mm-hmm. Mm-hmm.

01:52:29
How many different units it took to make up take up the active duty units that were short because of the cutbacks we get we're pulling all people from all these little divisions and companies that National Guard Reserve.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:52:46
You did an amazing job documenting everything. Are you okay to hang in there for a few more questions? You doing okay?

01:52:53
Okay. Um We kinda we discussed that the relationships that you made, you know, was a huge I mean that was very significant with the quilt. Was there even more significance?

01:53:05
Um, you know, by the time you were done making this quilt, I'm sure, obviously just watching you work with the quilt. It's something that really means a lot to you clearly and it's very special to you. Is there anything you wanted to add about, you know, what it meant to you or what it means to you?

Nicole Smith
01:53:22
No, it's just It's something that'll always be a part of me. Always. It'll be a part of not just me, but um all the all the wonderful people that I did meet while I was there.

01:53:37
They uh just memories. You know, it's something I'll have for the rest of my life. And it's something that to share with somebody.

01:53:49
Mmm, just something different. I had fun do me. Clearly.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:53:55
Clearly Um, I I know that you said you had trouble bringing it through customs, along with some other souvenirs that you brought back.

Nicole Smith
01:54:03
Yes, yes. Um 'Cause it was they thought it was the dirty and bugs and stuff like that. And then um once I opened it up and they realized what it was and they saw it, they were like And it's like go ahead sign it.

01:54:18
So a lot of m you know, they signed it and everything and it was all good to go. And uh I had a uh headstone made out of. Um a piece of Italian marble from Saddam's Palace that we bombed.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:54:30
Mm-hmm.

Nicole Smith
01:54:31
And but uh it I had it engraved with my son's name and everything and it is now sitting on my

son's grave that is he's buried on top of my grandfather in Duncan, Pennsylvania, up on the hill in the cemetery. And it's right there. So a piece of Saddam's palace is in Perry County, Pennsylvania in a graveyard on a Christian grave.

01:54:57
That's pretty. I just thought it was kind of ironic the the significance and everything. My little way of uh you know thumbing myself at Saddam.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:55:11
You know, you said when you joined the service that you wanted to better yourself, you wanted to improve your life. Do you feel that you've successfully done that?

Nicole Smith
01:55:20
Absolutely. Absolutely. Always do the right thing.

01:55:25
Mm-hmm. Everything they teach us in the army, they teach us for a reason. Is uh what is that, leadership Loyalty, duty, respect, honor, integrity, and selfless service.

01:55:41
And I forgot the P. I always forget what the P is for. But all that, I mean, I've ingrained it into myself with my personal life as well as my military. And it's a Yeah, definitely.

01:55:56
They say for every every deed you do, good or bad, it comes back on you tenfold. Yeah, it does. I believe that wholeheartedly So I try not to do anything bad anymore.

01:56:08
I don't like the repercussions.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:56:12
Now I just wanted to touch on only a couple of questions left. But I think it's really I just your s your story is just so fascinating to me. You you've touched on a few different stories about, you know, um women being in Iraq. As a woman serving in Iraq, um is what I don't know what you'd like to share with us, but your perspective It sucked.

Nicole Smith
01:56:34
Seriously it did. As a woman in Iraq, you are outnumbered by men, you know, like A hundred to one. Mm-hmm. And it's absolutely ridiculous. Uh women you have to be very careful down there And things happen and you have no control over things, other people.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:56:55
You just have to be really, really careful. Especially I would imagine since the attitude they have toward toward women out there.

Nicole Smith
01:57:03
Yeah, definitely. Definitely. Okay. But then you stand your ground at the same time too.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:57:09
And just really quickly, I'm I'm almost there. Um I think you said that you wound up having to sign names on the back of the quilt because you you ran out of room on the one side

Nicole Smith
01:57:18
Yes, we ran out of room on the back of it because there's so much there that we started signing that's why the first ID band took a whole block and they put their name on it. Mm-hmm. And some of the other um spots we took and people just signed started signing their names.

01:57:35
Mm-hmm. And uh like different the different units that we'd come across. Mm-hmm.

01:57:39
If we came across um, you know, one soldier that's from he's only attached, but he's from that unit. Mm-hmm. We like this one.

01:57:48
You know? These were the three guys that were attached to another unit, but this is where they were from. They put their name inside it and all that stuff.

01:57:58
Okay

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:57:59
Last very last question, is there anything I did not ask that I should have that you would like to add? Anything at all?

Nicole Smith
01:58:06
Not that I can think of.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:58:08
Okay.

Nicole Smith
01:58:09
Not that I can think of. Okay